Specification of the controlled designation of origin "CHINON"

CHAPTER I

I. – Name of the designation

Only wines meeting the specific provisions set out below may claim the controlled designation of origin "Chinon", initially recognised by the decree of 31 July 1937.

II. – Geographical denominations and complementary terms

The name of the controlled designation of origin may be supplemented by the geographical denomination "Val de Loire" according to the rules fixed in the present specification for the use of this geographical denomination.

III. – Types of product

The controlled designation of origin "Chinon" is reserved for still white, red and rosé wines.

IV. – Areas and zones in which the various operations are carried out

1° – Geographical area

The harvesting of the grapes, the vinification, the elaboration and the ageing of the wines are carried out within the territory of the following communes of the Indre-et-Loire department: Anché, Avoine, Avon-les-Roches, Beaumont-en-Véron, Brizay, Candes-Saint-Martin, Chinon, Cinais, Couziers, Cravant-les-Côteaux, Crouzilles, Huismes, L'Ile-Bouchard, Lerné, Ligré, Panzoult, Rivière, La Roche-Clermault, Saint-Benoît-la-Forêt, Saint-Germain-sur-Vienne, Savigny-en-Véron, Sazilly, Seuilly, Tavant, Theneuil, Thizay.

2° – Delimited parcel area

The wines come exclusively from vines situated within the delimited parcel production area as approved by the National Institute of Origin and Quality at the sessions of the competent national committee of 21 and 22 May 1996, 10 February 2016 and 12 February 2026.

The National Institute of Origin and Quality lodges with the town halls of the communes referred to in 1° the graphic documents establishing the parcel boundaries of the production area thus approved. The cartographic documents representing the delimited parcel area may be consulted on the website of the National Institute of Origin and Quality.

3° – Immediate proximity area

The immediate proximity area, defined by derogation for the vinification, the elaboration and the ageing of the wines, is made up of the territory of the following communes:

Indre-et-Loire department: Azay-le-Rideau, Benais, Bourgueil, La Chapelle-sur-Loire, Chaveignes, Chezelles, Chouzé-sur-Loire, Crissay-sur-Manse, Ingrandes-de-Touraine, Marçay, Restigné, Rigny-Ussé, Rivarennes, Saché, Saint-Nicolas-de-Bourgueil, Saint-Patrice, La Tour-Saint- Gelin, Trogues

Maine-et-Loire department: Fontevraud-l'Abbaye, Montsoreau, Parnay, Saint-Cyr-en-Bourg, Modification du cahier des charges de l'AOP « Chinon » adoptée par le Comité National des Appellations d'Origine relatives aux vins et aux boissons alcoolisées, et des boissons spiritueuses en séance du 12 février 2026. Turquant, Varrains

V. – Grape varieties

1° – Grape varieties

a) – The red and rosé wines come from the following varieties: - main variety: cabernet franc N; - accessory variety: cabernet-sauvignon N.

b) – The white wines come from the chenin B variety.

2° – Proportion rules on the holding

The proportion of the cabernet-sauvignon N variety is less than or equal to 10 % of the grape varieties.

VI. – Management of the vineyard

1° – Training method

a) – Planting density.
The vines present a minimum planting density of 4,500 plants per hectare, with a spacing between rows of 2.10 metres maximum. The spacing between plants within the same row may not be less than 1 metre.

b) – Pruning rules.
The vines are pruned with a maximum of 11 free eyes (buds) per plant according to the following techniques: - single Guyot pruning; - pruning with 2 half-canes; - short spur pruning. The vines are disbudded or thinned so as to obtain, at fruit-set (Lorenz phenological stage 27), a maximum of 11 fruit-bearing shoots per plant.

c) – Trellising rules and foliage height.
The vines are compulsorily trained in the "raised single-plane trellising". The height of the trellised foliage must be at least equal to 0.6 times the spacing between rows, the height of trellised foliage being measured between the lower limit of the foliage, established at least 0.30 metre above the ground, and the upper topping limit, established at least 0.20 metre above the upper trellising wire.

d) – Average maximum load per parcel.
The average maximum load is fixed, per parcel, at 9,500 kilograms per hectare.

e) – Thresholds for missing vines.
The percentage of dead or missing vine plants referred to in Article D. 645-4 of the Rural and Maritime Fishing Code is fixed at 20 %.

f) – Cultivation condition of the vine.
The parcels are managed so as to ensure a good overall cultivation condition of the vine, in particular its sanitary condition and the upkeep of the soil.

2° – Other cultivation practices

In order to preserve the characteristics of the physical and biological environment that constitutes a fundamental element of the terroir: - a plant cover of the headlands is compulsory at a minimum of 1.50 metre from the anchoring point of the trellising of the vine, and this distance is brought to 2.50 metres when the soil is maintained mechanically; - on the inter-row, either a soil tillage is carried out or a plant cover, sown or spontaneous, is present, and, in the latter case, the control of the vegetation is carried out either by mechanical means or by equipment allowing a precise localisation of the treatment products.

VII. – Harvest, transport and ripeness of the grapes

1° – Harvest

The wines come from grapes harvested at proper ripeness.

2° – Ripeness of the grapes

The sugar contents of the grapes and the natural alcoholic strengths by volume meet the following characteristics:

COLOUR OF THE WINES	MINIMUM SUGAR CONTENT OF THE GRAPES (grams per litre of must)	MINIMUM NATURAL ALCOHOLIC STRENGTH BY VOLUME
White wines	162	10.0 %
Rosé wines	171	10.5 %
Red wines	180	10.5 %

VIII. – Yields. – Entry into production

1° – Yield

The yield referred to in Article D. 645-7 of the Rural and Maritime Fishing Code is fixed at 55 hectolitres per hectare.

2° – Limit yield

a) – The limit yield referred to in Article D. 645-7 of the Rural and Maritime Fishing Code is fixed, for the red and rosé wines, at 67 hectolitres per hectare.

b) – The limit yield referred to in Article D. 645-7 of the Rural and Maritime Fishing Code is fixed, for the white wines, at 69 hectolitres per hectare.

4° – Entry into production of young vines

The benefit of the controlled designation of origin may be granted to wines coming from:

- parcels of young vines only from the 2nd year following that in the course of which planting was carried out in place before 31 July;

- parcels of young vines only from the 1st year following that in the course of which grafting in place was carried out before 31 July;

- parcels of vines that have been top-grafted, at the earliest in the 1st year following that in the course of which the top-grafting was carried out before 31 July, and once the parcels no longer contain any varieties other than those permitted for the appellation. By way of derogation, in the year following that in the course of which the top-grafting was carried out before 31 July, the varieties permitted for the appellation may represent only 80 % of the grape varieties of each parcel concerned.

IX. – Processing, elaboration, ageing, packaging, storage

1° – General provisions

The wines are vinified in accordance with local, fair and constant usages.

a) – Blending of the varieties. The red and rosé wines come from the main variety alone or from a blend of grapes or wines in which the main variety is predominant. The wines may not come from the accessory variety alone.

b) – Malolactic fermentation. The malolactic fermentation is completed for the red wines. The malic acid content is less than or equal to 0.3 gram per litre.

c) – Analytical standards. After packaging, the wines present the following analytical standards:

COLOUR OF THE WINES	**MAXIMUM CONTENT OF FERMENTABLE SUGARS (glucose + fructose) (grams per litre)**	**TOTAL ACIDITY CONTENT**
White wines	6	The total acidity content, expressed in grams of tartaric acid per litre, is not lower, by more than 2 grams per litre, than the content of fermentable sugars.
Rosé wines	4	The total acidity content, expressed in grams of tartaric acid per litre, is greater than 3.5 grams per litre.
Red wines	2	

d) – Oenological practices and physical treatments. - For the elaboration of the rosé wines, the use of charcoals for oenological use, alone or in a mixture in preparations, is prohibited. - The subtractive enrichment techniques are authorised for the red wines and the maximum rate of partial concentration in relation to the volumes used is fixed at 10 %. - The wines do not exceed, after enrichment, a total alcoholic strength by volume of 13 %.

e) – Vat capacity. Every operator demonstrates an overall vat capacity equivalent at least to 1 times the volume of the previous harvest, at equal area.

f) – Overall upkeep of the cellar and equipment. The cellar (floors and walls) and the vinification equipment present a good general condition of upkeep.

2° – Provisions by type of product

The red wines undergo ageing at least until 14 December of the year of harvest.

3° – Provisions relating to packaging

For each packaged lot, the operator keeps available for the approved control body: - the information appearing in the register of handling operations referred to in Article D. 645-18 of the Rural and Maritime Fishing Code; - an analysis carried out before or after packaging. The analysis reports are kept for a period of 6 months from the date of packaging.

4° – Provisions relating to storage

The operator demonstrates a suitable place for the storage of the packaged products.

5° – Provisions relating to the movement of products and to placing on the market for the consumer

Date of placing on the market for the consumer. - The white and rosé wines are placed on the market for the consumer according to the provisions of Article D. 645-17 of the Rural and Maritime Fishing Code. - At the end of the ageing period, the red wines are placed on the market for the consumer from 1 January of the year following that of the harvest.

X. – Link with the geographical area

1° – Information on the geographical area

a) – Description of the natural factors contributing to the link

The vineyard is established along the valley of the Vienne, as well as on the left banks of the Indre and the Loire. On either side of the Vienne, it occupies the hillsides and the edges of the plateaux, whereas in the region of the Véron, the zone of confluence with the Loire, it is found at the heart of a more open landscape.

On the 26 communes of the Indre-et-Loire department whose territories constitute the geographical area, the most characteristic soils arise either from the different sedimentary formations of the Upper Cretaceous — the Cenomanian, the Turonian and the Senonian (soft chalks of the Turonian, and clayey-siliceous formations of the Senonian) — or from the free-draining sandy-gravelly formations of the major bed of the Vienne.

Situated at the western extremity of the Touraine, the geographical area benefits from a climate of oceanic to semi-continental type, particularly warmer and drier than the rest of the region. In spring, the mildness of the temperatures allows an early start of the vegetation. The presence of southern and even subtropical plant species (magnolia, fig trees, palm trees, etc.) testifies to the particular climatic characteristics of the geographical area. They are linked to the beneficial influence of the air currents generated by the two watercourses, effecting a natural drainage of the cold air masses.

b) – Description of the human factors contributing to the link

As attested by the numerous regional archaeological discoveries (vine pollens, grape pips, winegrowers' tools, presses, dolia, sites of amphora production), the Touraine has, since Antiquity, been a wine-producing and wine-exporting region. The vine is cultivated in the region of Chinon from the Gallo-Roman period, Chinon being already an important road and river crossroads, at the mouth of the Vienne on the Loire. As in the whole Val de Loire, the river trade has here favoured the establishment and the development of viticulture.

In the 11th century, the hagiographic account of the life and the miracles of Saint Mexme, evangeliser of the Touraine, mentions an owner of Chinon transporting his wine by the river as far as Nantes, where he hopes to obtain a better price for it. Under the domination of the Plantagenets, Chinon becomes the centre

of an immense feudal domain and its wines are served at the Court. The cabernet franc N variety, already present in the South-West, is established in the region, at this period, by going up the Loire from Nantes. This earns it being locally called "breton". Rabelais designates it thus in his "Gargantua" (1534 – book I, chapter XIII): "this good breton wine, which does not grow in Brittany but in this good country of Véron [the Chinon region]".

The numerous underground quarries hollowed out, at the foot of the hillsides, in the "tuffeau" (soft chalky formation of the Turonian) to extract the ashlar stones were subsequently used as sites for the elaboration and sometimes the storage of the wine. Despite the vicissitudes of history and the ordeal of the phylloxera crisis, the Chinon winegrowers have always reconstituted their vineyard on the historically cultivated sectors, preserving the cabernet franc N to which they are strongly attached, thus showing their wish to perpetuate their viticultural traditions. The community of winegrowers founds, on 24 May 1937, a union for the defence of the wines of Chinon. The controlled designation of origin "Chinon" is recognised on 31 July 1937.

The area of the vineyard goes from 550 hectares in 1937 to 2,400 hectares in 2009. It is exploited by a little more than 200 winegrowers, for an average production of 125,000 hectolitres. The red wines, with 90 % of the volumes, represent the essential production, whereas the productions of rosé wines (8 % of the volumes) and of white wines (2 % of the volumes) are more confidential.

2° – Information on the quality and characteristics of the products

The wines benefiting from the controlled designation of origin "Chinon" are still and dry wines. The white wines possess a certain natural acidity which allows them to enrich their aromatic palette with time. The fruity and floral aromas of their youth sometimes give way to soft notes of evolution that may recall honey, grilled almond or quince. The rosé wines, of a generally moderately sustained and frank colour, often possess aromas of red and white fruits, fresh and fairly intense, sometimes supported by a note of citrus or pepper.

The red wines have a colour that may range from dark ruby to deep garnet. They are elegant, with a tannic structure that is often well present but melted, and an original aromatic expression dominated by notes of small red and black fruits. Some, more opulent, gain from being kept a few years and may then reveal more complex notes, slightly smoky, cocoa-like, or spicy.

3° – Causal interactions

The particular climate of the zone of confluence between the Loire and the Vienne offers the cabernet franc N variety — a variety of the 2nd period, here close to the limit of its cultivation zone — conditions particularly favourable to obtaining authentic and elegant wines. Reflecting the usages, the delimited parcel area for the harvesting of the grapes retains only the brown soils, or shallow soils on glauconitic chalk of the Turonian, and the shallow sandy-clayey or sandy-gravelly soils. These soils present a good water and thermal behaviour. A good openness of the landscape is favoured in order to benefit from the particular climatic conditions. These situations impose an optimal management of the plant and of its production potential by the training of the vine and a short pruning.

The viticultural situations exploited on the Turonian substratum are conducive to the production of red wines having a good tannic structure. The situations exploited on the sandy-clayey or sandy-gravelly soils are favourable to a fruity aromatic expression in the wines. The know-how of the elaborators, acquired from the experience of several generations, is then expressed in the blending of the wines from the different situations. This know-how, adapted to the specific conditions of this territory first dedicated to the production of red wine, has naturally been adapted for the production of the rosé wines and the white wines.

Viticulture is, at Chinon, intimately linked to the geo-pedology and to the presence of the watercourses. The Loire, the Indre and the Vienne have, by erosion, cleared the hillsides and plateau edges, resulting in the formation of lean soils, and deposited free-draining alluvium, conducive to viticulture. These watercourses were also natural routes of communication and trade, used since Antiquity. In the 18th century, this is particularly active with the Dutch trade, via the port of Nantes. One then spoke, for these quality wines of Touraine, of "sea wines". One could not evoke "Chinon" and its wines, at the Renaissance, without mentioning François Rabelais, born around 1490 at La Devinière, a house that his

father owned at Seuilly, a few kilometres from Chinon, and who praised the quality of the wines of the region in his "Gargantua" (1534). In 1539, Guillaume Poyet, chancellor of France originally from Angers, writes to the aldermen of his native town to recommend that they buy wines "of Orléans, Gascony and Véron [the Chinon region]", to honour their guests. The human community maintains the notoriety and the reputation of the wines of "Chinon" thanks to its dynamism, to its know-how, to its attachment to the cabernet franc N variety, and by gathering together in the confraternity of the "Entonneurs rabelaisiens", created in 1961.

XI. – Transitional measures

1° – Delimited parcel area

On a transitional basis, the parcels planted with vine excluded from the delimited parcel area of the controlled designation of origin, identified by their cadastral references, their area and their grape varieties, the list of which was approved by the competent national committee at the sessions of 21 and 22 May 1996, provided that they meet the conditions fixed by the present specification, continue to benefit, for their harvest, from the right to the controlled designation of origin until they are grubbed up and at the latest until the 2025 harvest inclusive.

2° – Training method

a) – The vine parcels in place on 1 October 1997, and not respecting the provisions relating to planting density fixed in the present specification, continue to benefit, for their harvest, from the right to the controlled designation of origin until they are grubbed up and at the latest until the 2025 harvest inclusive, subject to compliance with the trellising and foliage-height rules fixed in the present specification.

XII. – Rules of presentation and labelling

1° – General provisions

Wines for which, under the terms of the present specification, the controlled designation of origin is claimed and which are presented under the said appellation may not be declared after the harvest, offered to the public, dispatched, put up for sale or sold unless, in the harvest declaration, in advertisements, on leaflets, labels, invoices and any containers whatsoever, the aforesaid controlled designation of origin is entered.

2° – Particular provisions

a) – All the optional terms whose use, by virtue of the Community provisions, may be regulated by the Member States, are entered, on the labels, in characters whose dimensions, both in height and in width, are not greater than double those of the characters composing the name of the controlled designation of origin.

b) – The dimensions of the characters of the geographical denomination "Val de Loire" are not greater, both in height and in width, than two-thirds of those of the characters composing the name of the controlled designation of origin.

c) – The labelling of the wines benefiting from the controlled designation of origin may specify the name of a smaller geographical unit, provided that: - it is a registered cadastral lieu-dit; - it appears on the harvest declaration.

CHAPTER II

I. – Declaration obligations

1. Declaration of renunciation to produce

Every operator declares to the defence and management body, at the latest 72 hours before the harvest, the parcels for which it renounces to produce the controlled designation of origin. The defence and management body transmits this information to the approved control body as soon as possible.

2. Claim declaration

The claim declaration is sent to the defence and management body before 10 December of the year of harvest. It indicates in particular: - the designation claimed; - the volume of the wine; - the colour; - the

EVV or SIRET number; - the name and address of the operator; - the place of storage of the wine. It is accompanied by a copy of the harvest declaration and, as the case may be, a copy of the production declaration or an extract of the stock accounts for buyers of grapes and musts.

3. Prior declaration of transactions

Every operator declares each bulk transaction to the approved control body within time limits fixed in the inspection plan, which may not exceed fifteen working days before the operation. This declaration, accompanied where applicable by a copy of the purchase contract, specifies in particular: - the name of the appellation and the colour; - the identity of the operator; - the EVV or SIRET number; - the identification of the lot; - the volume of the lot; - the identification of the containers; - the identity of the buyer.

4. Prior declaration of packaging

a) – Every operator packaging a wine of the controlled designation of origin, not demonstrating a certified system of traceability and of sample conservation, makes, to the approved control body, a packaging declaration, at the latest within the 24 hours following the completion of the packaging of the lot(s) of wine; b) – Every operator packaging a wine of the controlled designation of origin, demonstrating a certified system of traceability and of sample conservation, keeps a special register recording each packaging according to the arrangements fixed in the inspection plan.

5. Declaration relating to the dispatch outside the national territory of a non-packaged wine

Every operator wishing to carry out a dispatch outside the national territory of a non-packaged wine benefiting from the controlled designation of origin makes the declaration thereof to the approved control body within time limits fixed in the inspection plan, which may not exceed fifteen working days before any dispatch.

6. Fallback (repli) declaration

Every operator marketing a wine benefiting from the controlled designation of origin under a more general appellation makes the declaration thereof to the defence and management body and to the approved control body at least fifteen days before this fallback.

7. Downgrading declaration

Every operator carrying out a downgrading of wine benefiting from the controlled designation of origin sends to the defence and management body and to the approved control body a downgrading declaration at the latest on the 20th of the month following the day of the downgrading(s) carried out. It indicates in particular: - the name of the appellation and the colour of the product concerned; - the identity of the operator and its EVV or SIRET number; - the volume of wine downgraded; - the balance of volume remaining claimed under the controlled designation of origin for the colour of the product concerned.

II. – Keeping of registers

1. Ripeness register

Every operator producing grapes intended for the production of wines of the controlled designation of origin keeps up to date a register on which is specified the evolution of the ripeness of the grapes by the recording of the potential alcoholic strength by volume. At least two checks are carried out.

2. Vines under transitional provisions

a) – Every operator exploiting vine parcels in place on 1 October 1997 and not meeting the provisions relating to planting density fixed in the present specification keeps up to date a register on which is indicated, for the parcels concerned: - the cadastral reference; - the area; - the year of planting; - the variety; - the planting density; - the spacings on the row and between the rows.

b) – Every operator exploiting vine parcels in place on 1 January 1992, planted with the chenin B variety, not meeting the provisions relating to the pruning rules fixed in the present specification, keeps up to date a register on which is indicated, for the parcels concerned: - the cadastral reference; - the area; - the year of planting; - the planting density; - the spacings on the row and between the rows.

CHAPTER III

I – Main points to be checked and evaluation methods

MAIN POINTS TO BE CHECKED	EVALUATION METHODS
A – STRUCTURAL RULES	
A1 – Belonging of the planted parcels to the delimited area and monitoring of the transitional measures.	Documentary check and check in the field.
A2 – Claimable production potential (grape varieties and proportion rules, monitoring of transitional measures, planting density and trellising).	Documentary check.
A3 – Processing, ageing, packaging and storage facilities. — Vat capacity.	Check in the field.
B – RULES LINKED TO THE PRODUCTION CYCLE	
B1 – Management of the vineyard. — Fruit-bearing shoots.	Check in the field.
Other cultivation practices.	Check in the field.
Average maximum load per parcel.	Check in the field.
B2 – Harvest, transport and ripeness of the grapes. — Natural alcoholic strength by volume.	Documentary check and check.
B3 – Processing, elaboration, ageing, packaging, storage. — Monitoring of the vinification.	Documentary check and check.
Compliance with the date of placing on the market for the consumer.	Documentary check and check.
B4 – Harvest declaration and claim declaration. — Authorised yield.	Documentary check.
C – CHECKS ON THE PRODUCTS	
Non-packaged wines that are the subject of a transaction between operators.	Analytical and organoleptic examination.
Wines ready to be placed on the market for the consumer (in bulk or packaged).	Analytical and organoleptic examination.
Non-packaged wines intended for a dispatch outside the national territory.	Analytical and organoleptic examination of all the lots.

II – References concerning the control structure

National Institute of Origin and Quality (INAO)
TSA 30003
93555 – MONTREUIL-SOUS-BOIS Cedex
Tel: (33) (0)1.73.30.38.00
Fax: (33) (0)1.73.30.38.04
Email: infocontact@inao.gouv.fr

The check of compliance with the present specification is carried out by a third-party body offering guarantees of competence, impartiality and independence, under the authority of the INAO, on the basis of an approved inspection plan.

The inspection plan sets out the self-checks carried out by the operators on their own activity and the internal checks carried out under the responsibility of the defence and management body. It indicates the external checks carried out by the third-party body as well as the analytical and organoleptic examinations. The whole of the checks is carried out by sampling. Non-packaged wines intended for a dispatch outside the national territory are the subject of a systematic analytical and organoleptic check.